

Total Recovery

Widow's Bight, 193_

Ward Kohistani had built his whole method on a single, load-bearing conviction: that nothing worth finding was worth finding partially. A site excavated at ninety percent was a site vandalized by its own excavator — the missing ten was not absence, it was evidence you had thrown away with your own hands, out of impatience or fatigue or the fear of what the last handful of soil might contain. *Total recovery*. He had written the phrase in the front of every field notebook he'd ever owned, underlined twice, and had never once, in eleven years of digging, needed to ask himself what it cost.

He counted this a virtue. He was thirty-four years old and had never once wondered whether a method built to leave nothing behind might, eventually, come looking for the one thing it hadn't yet accounted for.

The British Archaeological Society had sent him to Widow's Bight the way a man sends a servant to close up a summer house — a lesser posting, transparently, while the Society's real attention and its real money went to Egypt, to a boy king's tomb and the newspapers that couldn't stop writing about it. Ward read the assignment differently, because he had spent his whole life being handed the lesser posting and needing, each time, to read it as opportunity instead. His mother's family had a name in two countries and full standing in neither — Anglo on paper, Afghan by blood, welcomed by the Crown exactly as far as the Crown found the welcome useful and not one step further. He had learned, young, that the surest way to be let all the way into a room was to be so plainly, undeniably right about something that the room had no further grounds to keep him out of it. Widow's Bight, a drowned wreck off a forgotten stretch of New England coast, would be that thing. He intended to be more thorough here than anyone in the Society's history had ever been thorough about anything, and to make that thoroughness impossible to file away as a lesser posting's lesser result.

He had brought, along with his instruments and his field kit, a private conviction he had never once said aloud to a colleague: that a man who left nothing behind him was a man who could never be dismissed the way he himself had spent a career being dismissed. Total recovery was not, whatever he told the Society in his correspondence, a methodology. It was an argument he was making about his own right to exist in a room, conducted one catalogued trinket at a time.

The locals called the laborers who worked the ruins the Observers, and Ward filed the name the way he filed everything, without much interest — folk superstition dressed as an occupational title, the kind of thing every dig site accumulated the way a boat accumulates barnacles. They worked the drowned island with a patience he found admirable and a caution he found faintly comic: men who would haul stone all day without complaint and then stop dead, refuse a task outright, over some feature Ward could see nothing wrong with. They were, he noted in passing and did not think about again, oddly colorless to look at against the bright New England light — as if the sun simply declined to find them interesting — except for the jewelry a few of them wore, and the wet stone under their lantern-fires, which caught color the way nothing else on that gray coast did. He wrote *possible sumptuary custom, investigate* in the margin of a field notebook and never did.

On his second day a young one — younger than Ward, a boy really, apprenticed to an older man whose hands shook faintly with age but whose eye, Ward noted, never once missed where a beam had shifted — stood at the mouth of the lower gallery and would not go down it. The old man did not scold him. He simply nodded, once, the way a teacher nods at a student who has correctly answered a question, and took the boy's place himself.

"He's young to be given the dangerous work," Ward said, more to make conversation than because he expected an answer.

The old man looked at him for a long moment — not unkindly, the specific patient look of someone deciding how much of an explanation a stranger has earned. "He isn't given it," he said. "He'll ask for it himself, one day. Not yet."

Ward wrote *apprenticeship structure, informal, merit-based(?)* and filed it beside the sumptuary note, and did not ask what the boy would need to learn before he asked.

The ruin itself was extraordinary and he loved it with the specific, undivided love of a man who has finally been given the room to be as thorough as he actually is. Chambers below chambers. Corridors that predated any architecture he could confidently date, hung with objects in a state of preservation the salt water should never have allowed. He built his system in the first week and never revised it, because it worked, because it was elegant, because it was, he told himself, exactly what total recovery looked like when a man was finally permitted to practice it without a committee looking over his shoulder.

[ENTRY 001] *Carved bone toggle, provenance uncertain, condition fair.* [ENTRY 002] *Ballast stone, worked, function unclear.* [ENTRY 003] *Ship's fitting, bronze, heavily encrusted.*

The Codex logged everything. Every scrap of ballast, every knot of corroded rigging, every one of the thousand small worthless things a wreck accumulates the way a body accumulates scars,

entered in his own hand with the same rigor regardless of value — because value was a judgment, and judgment was exactly the thing total recovery existed to remove from the process. He had, by the end of the first month, some four hundred entries for objects a less disciplined man would never have bothered writing down at all, and perhaps thirty for objects that mattered — a scrimshawed tooth with a full ship's name still legible, a captain's seal, a length of chain whose links carried a maker's stamp he'd never seen catalogued anywhere. Ten slots in his own pack for what he could actually carry out of the ruin each day — weight mattered more than count, some single pieces heavy enough on their own to cost him two or three lesser trinkets just to keep his footing on the climb back — and thousands of entries in the Codex for what he couldn't, so that nothing, in principle, was ever truly lost.

The choosing was its own discipline, and he came, over the weeks, to almost enjoy it. A morning in the third week: a corroded ship's bell, heavy enough on its own that carrying it out meant leaving two or three lighter pieces behind just to keep his footing on the climb, sitting not four feet from a scrimshawed comb he'd been hunting since his first survey of the gallery. He stood there a full five minutes weighing them, literally, one in each hand, and set the bell down at last and took the comb and two lighter pieces instead, and noted the bell's exact position in the Codex — *observed, not recovered, marked for return* — with the calm of a man certain the return would come. It nearly always did. He went back for the bell eleven days later and it was exactly where he'd left it, and he felt, hauling it up the last ledge with his shoulders screaming, the specific clean satisfaction of a system working precisely as designed. Nothing about that morning ever suggested to him that the system might, eventually, ask for a choice it wouldn't let him revisit.

He got better at the leaps. Not through instruction — there was no one to instruct him — but through the plain accumulation of having done it enough times to feel, in his hands and his hips, where a landing would hold and where it wouldn't. In the second week he came down wrong from a ledge misjudged by less than a foot and felt something in his ankle give in a way that made the world go briefly, whitely quiet. He taped it himself, badly, and kept working, because a man who stopped for every small injury on a site like this would never finish it in a lifetime, let alone a season the Society had already signaled they resented funding.

By the fifth week the same ledge, and worse ones past it, cost him nothing at all. He noticed this the way he noticed a clean stratigraphic layer — with satisfaction, not surprise. He never once thought of it as a stat, a number climbing somewhere he couldn't see. He thought of it, correctly enough, as competence, and competence, in his experience, only ever compounded.

It did not make him safe. It only ever made him cheaper to hurt. A twisted ankle became a bruised one. A fall that would once have ended his season instead cost him three days of a limp he worked through anyway. And in the fourth week, landing wrong on a piece of rubble no better-judged leap could have avoided, because the rubble itself had shifted underfoot the

instant before his boot found it, he broke a toe that never fully set right and stayed with him the rest of the season — a small, persistent ache he catalogued the way he catalogued everything, without particular alarm. He understood, dimly and without ever articulating it to himself, that the ruin was never going to let him climb its worst places for free. Skill bought him a smaller bill. It did not buy him no bill at all. A weaker climber, he thought once, standing over the broken piece of rubble with his toe already swelling inside his boot, would simply not have reached this gallery to be hurt in it. He did not consider, standing there, what that thought implied about where competence was actually taking him.

It is worth setting down the morning that went well, because a man is not only the shape of what eventually costs him.

Deep in the fifth week, in a gallery he'd nearly skipped for a more promising-looking corridor to the east, he found — cleanly, on a single confident leap across a gap he'd have refused to attempt in his first fortnight — a sealed ossuary jar, undisturbed, its wax seal intact after what his own instruments told him was upward of two centuries underwater. He opened it that same afternoon in good light with steady hands, and inside, packed in a preservative silt he had never once seen a wreck produce before or since, lay a set of ship's instruments so complete and so exactly datable that he sat back on his heels afterward and laughed out loud, once, alone, in a stone corridor two hundred years older than any building he'd ever stood inside.

It was, for that one afternoon, everything the work was supposed to feel like and so rarely did: a clean leap, a genuine find, a discipline paying off exactly as promised, with no cost attached anywhere he could find one. He wrote the entry in his best hand and underlined the date twice, the way he'd once underlined *total recovery* itself, and went to bed that night more certain than he had been in years that he had finally been given the posting his whole career had been rehearsing for.

He did not know, and had no way yet of knowing, that this was the last entry the ruin would ever let him make for free.

The opium came from the same crate as the rest of his field kit, meant for exactly this — a working man's dig with working men's injuries, no physician for thirty miles. He used it first the honest way, the way it was meant: enough to make the ankle bearable, enough to keep working through a torn muscle that would otherwise have ended his season in its second month. It did precisely what the tin promised and nothing more. It dulled pain. It did not show him anything that was not there, did not warp a single color he looked at, did not so much as make the corridors seem longer than they were. He was, if anything, grateful for its honesty — a tool that did its stated job and no other was rarer, in his experience, than most men appreciated.

He noticed only much later, and only in the accounting sense a man like him could not help but apply to everything, that the intervals between uses had been shortening for some time, and that this had very little left to do with his toe.

Deep enough into the excavation — past the chambers any reasonable itinerary would have called complete — the corridor did something no corridor should. It kept going, dry stone underfoot where sea should long since have claimed the passage, running level and then very slightly downward, on and on, in a direction his own survey maps insisted led nowhere but open ocean.

[ENTRY 118] Officer's whistle, brass, corroded. Provenance uncertain.

He logged it without understanding why the word *officer* had come to his hand before he'd consciously decided what the object was. He turned it over once, noted the pitting, the salt damage, filed it as harbor debris carried in by some current he didn't need to explain, and moved on, because the alternative — that a stretch of tunnel with no earthly business connecting to anywhere had, in fact, connected to somewhere — was not a hypothesis total recovery had any use for. He recorded what geology could not permit and did not permit himself to dwell on it.

[ENTRY 119] Metal flask, corroded, cap missing. Contents: none. Provenance uncertain.

[ENTRY 121] —

He went back and checked. There was no entry 120. He had not skipped a page, had not torn one out; the numbering simply proceeded from a hundred nineteen to a hundred twenty-one as if his own hand had made the jump without him. He sat with his notebook open in bad lantern light for longer than he'd have admitted to anyone, recounted the whole page from the top, arrived at the same gap, and closed the book. A miscount. A man works long enough hours in bad enough light, he makes an error and doesn't remember making it. He told himself this with the same flat conviction he told himself most things, and it worked, mostly, the way it always had.

Further on, scuff marks in old silt, the kind that might have come from a boot dragged sideways in a hurry, or a body pulled somewhere it hadn't chosen to go. He photographed them, measured them, entered them as *evidence of prior disturbance, cause unknown*, and never once let himself wonder aloud what kind of struggle leaves no other trace at all. A more curious investigator — a man built along entirely different lines, in a different decade, with a badge instead of a trowel — might have known exactly what he was looking at. Ward only knew that it

belonged in the record, and put it there, because that was the one thing his method never let him refuse to do.

An Observer found him there, once, further down that corridor than any of the local laborers had ever willingly gone, and stood at the edge of his lantern light without a word — grayscale down to the collar, a single ring on the hand catching lamp-color no lamp had any business giving it. Ward asked, in the reasonable, patient tone he used on men he considered beneath argument, whether the man had something to report.

"You've come further than the season needs you to," the Observer said. It was the first full sentence any of them had spoken to him directly.

"The season needs precisely as far as the record requires," Ward said. "That is the whole of my discipline."

The Observer looked at him for a while with an expression Ward would, months later and far too late, recognize as pity. "We don't go past here because we know what's past here," he said. "Not because we're afraid of the dark. You should ask yourself, sometime before it matters, which one you think you are."

He turned and walked back the way he'd come without waiting for an answer.

Ward wrote *uncooperative, possible superstition re: this section* in his notebook, and did not follow him out, and did not, that night or any night after, ask himself the question he'd been handed.

The chapter's second real test came the following week, in a long gallery the sound alone told him was different before his lantern ever confirmed it.

The dig's earlier corridors had always carried sound badly — every footstep a smeared, muddy echo, every dripped stone landing somewhere behind where his ear placed it, the whole acoustic picture as cluttered and unreliable as an old projection reel run through a worn machine. He had gotten used to navigating half-blind by ear and trusting his eyes to correct the record. Here, for the first time, the sound sharpened. A dripped stone landed exactly where his ear said it would. His own breathing came back to him crisp off the far wall, close enough to count. He could hear, with an exactness that startled him, the particular scrape of something heavy being dragged, unhurried, forty yards ahead and slightly below.

He told himself the clarity was simply better stone — a drier gallery, tighter walls, nothing more sinister than good acoustics — and used it exactly as he'd have used any other tool that suddenly worked better than expected. He placed the dragging sound precisely, placed a second, fainter one behind it, and picked his route along a ledge that ran the gallery's whole length specifically to keep both sounds beneath him and to his left rather than in front. It worked perfectly. He crossed the entire gallery without once losing his footing or his bearings, and told himself, reaching the far side, that the improved acoustics were simply one more piece of good fortune in a season that had been unusually generous with him.

He did not ask himself, crossing that ledge with such total, earned confidence, what kind of gallery rewards a man with better hearing directly in proportion to how much further it wants him to go.

The bloated dead were the first thing in that ruin his method had no honest answer for. He came on them from above, along a ledge he'd have sworn no man his size could hold, and understood before his conscious mind had finished the sentence that whatever lay tangled along the passage floor below him had once, in some cases, been men, and in other cases had simply drowned the way anything drowns, indifferent and unchosen, caught here the way driftwood is caught. The ledge ran the whole length of the chamber, a genuine route, if a man kept his nerve and his footing. He had both, by then, in more supply than he'd started the season with.

He nearly didn't use it. There was a piece down among them — he could see the shape of it even from above, worked metal, old beyond anything else he'd catalogued, a fitting or a fixture he had no name for yet and badly wanted one — and the total-recovery instinct that had carried him his whole career told him, with real conviction, that leaving a find like that behind because of what surrounded it was exactly the kind of failure of nerve his whole method existed to overrule. He got as far as one foot off the ledge, testing the drop, before something in him — not caution exactly, something closer to the animal sense a badly-set toe teaches a man whether he wants the lesson or not — pulled the foot back.

Below him, one of the shapes shifted. Not the ordinary slow settling of a bloated, waterlogged thing finding a new position under its own dead weight — a groan, plain and without patience in it, the specific sound he'd have expected disturbed silt and gas to make. He stood very still and let it settle again. Nothing else moved. He filed the sound, without particular alarm, as confirmation of what he'd already assumed: careless footing here meant a slide onto a floor no man wanted to slide onto, nothing more exotic than that.

He did not go down. He does not, afterward, know precisely why, only that some version of himself argued the case and lost, for once, to a version that wanted to survive the season more than it wanted a complete Codex. He left the piece where it lay, entered it in his notes as

observed, not recovered, location marked for return, and kept to the ledge until the chamber ended.

He would never know, because the ruin does not explain itself to the men it lets live a little longer, that the ledge had been the only route that was ever actually there. That the piece below had been resting exactly where it was for a reason with nothing to do with archaeology at all. That a man who had gone down among them — for the metal, for the completeness, for the total in total recovery — would not have come back up to write anything in any notebook at all. This was not a fight he could have won by any measure of skill or nerve. It was never a fight. It was a test of whether he could, for once, let something stay lost, and he was, that once, exactly disciplined enough to pass a test his own discipline had never once prepared him to recognize as a test.

The opium ran out in the sixth week, cleanly and honestly, the way it had always promised to. No hallucination arrived to replace it. No color bled where it shouldn't. It simply stopped working, because there was none left to work, and the ankle and the toe and the accumulating small violences of the ruin arrived all at once, undulled, and from that point on the exploration Ward had been so proud of narrowed, without any dramatic turn he could point to, into something closer to a slide. He was no longer choosing corridors. He was following the one his own curiosity had already committed him to, because turning back now would mean the season had failed, and failure was the one entry his Codex had never been built to hold.

He noticed, distantly, that the gallery's acoustic clarity — the gift that had carried him so cleanly past the bloated dead — had gone on sharpening even after there was nothing left in his kit to reward him for noticing it. Every footstep now arrived to him with a precision that had stopped feeling like fortune and started feeling, though he could not have said when the change occurred, like attention. Something, somewhere down that corridor, was listening exactly as well as he was, and had been for some time.

He found the book two nights before the end, wedged with a stack of a dead predecessor's field notes in a niche no team roster listed anyone having reached before him — pocket-sized, water-stained, a chapter on Aegean mystery cult underlined in a cramped, decades-old hand he did not recognize and had no reason to. He read the underlined passage by lantern light and felt something in his chest go very still and very cold, in a way no artifact in eleven years of careful work had ever made him feel.

Ophion — a serpent-power of the old cosmogony, said to have ruled before the younger gods cast him down. Not slain. Displaced. The distinction, the ancient sources insist, is not incidental.

Beneath the underlined passage, in a hand that pressed too hard into the page, someone before him had written a single line and then, apparently, thought better of finishing it: *They believed* —

He took out his own pencil, and began, beside that stranger's hand, to write his own notes in the margin — real ones, rigorous ones, the first entries in weeks he made purely because he wanted to understand something rather than because his method obliged him to record it. He did not know whose hand had come before his own. He would never know. He filled the margin anyway, methodically, the way he'd have filled it for any source worth the effort, and did not think, writing it, that a third hand might one day read both his and the stranger's without knowing either name, and would understand, from the two very different kinds of urgency pressed into the same page, exactly which one had been chasing a delusion and which one had been chasing the truth.

[ENTRY 214] *Book. Provenance: unknown. Condition: fair. Prior owner: unknown. Contents: —*

There was no room on the page to finish the description. He had, for the first time all season, run out of space in his own Codex, and did not, in that moment, find it strange that the one entry it couldn't hold was the one that mattered.

He went on because he had always gone on. Curiosity had built his whole career and it was not going to abandon him now merely because the thing it had finally found was larger than a career could hold. He dug because he wanted meaning. He found because he wanted glory. He persisted because he wanted, more than either, to be significant to a Society that had sent him here to be forgotten. And he understood, at the very last, in the same clean rigorous hand he'd used for every entry before it, because by then he could no longer stop himself from understanding.

Somewhere in that final stretch, walking a tunnel that had by then stopped even pretending to answer to a survey map, he thought, with sudden and total clarity, of the Observer's question — *which one you think you are* — and understood, far too late for the understanding to do him any good, that he had spent an entire season assuming the answer was self-evident, and had never once actually stopped to check it. The Observers refused ground not out of ignorance but out of a caution that had cost them, over generations, exactly what it was meant to save them: they knew, the way a miner knows to respect gas, precisely how far a man could go and still climb back out a man. Ward had spent eleven years building a method whose entire premise was that no ground existed which shouldn't, eventually, be gone over completely. He understood, walking that last stretch, that his method and their caution had been answering the same question the whole time, and that he had simply never once entertained the possibility that theirs might be the more sophisticated of the two.

The tunnel beneath the ruin ran on, level and dry, toward an ocean that had no business permitting it, and somewhere along that impossible distance the numbering in his Codex simply stopped meaning anything at all — entries out of order, entries for things he hadn't yet found and would never find, an entry, near what would prove to be the last page he ever filled, reading only *[ENTRY —] recovered in full* in his own hand, in ink, though he had no memory of writing it and nothing left in his pack to explain what it thought it was describing.

He was lost in the depths not long after.

What remained of him, and the pack he carried, and the Codex with its several thousand honest entries and its one entry that could not be finished, would lie undisturbed for the better part of a decade — long enough that no search the Society ever authorized came within a mile of finding it, long enough that his own name passed out of every roster that had once carried it, filed at last, by an institution that had sent him here expecting exactly this kind of quiet, uneventful disappointment, as an unfortunate but not especially remarkable loss. A wreck season, a lesser posting, a man who had gone too far into a ruin no one at the Society had ever seriously expected to yield anything worth the risk.

It would be another man's own hard year, walking ground he had even less reason than Ward to expect to survive, who came upon the remains at last — a stranger to Ward in every particular that could be named, carrying his own grief and his own unfinished argument with a town that had already decided what he was owed, and recognizing, in the careful ruin of another man's handwriting, something closer to kinship than either of them would ever have had the chance to call it aloud. He would never know Ward's name. He would carry what Ward found the rest of the way down regardless, the way any honest inheritor carries a debt he did not incur and cannot decline.

Whatever configuration of pack and page Ward had actually left behind — which pieces he'd carried out over the weeks and which he'd set back down, which entries he'd filled in full and which he'd left, like the last one, permanently unfinished — was simply what that later stranger would find, exactly as it had been left, because nothing about this ruin had ever needed to embellish what a man's own choices had already recorded honestly on his behalf.

Total recovery had been the whole of his method, the article of faith he'd built a career on, the thing he was certain, above everything else a man could be certain of, would never once let him down.

It got everything back. Every trinket. Every artifact. Every scrap of a dead cop's flask and a drowned crew's whistle, every page, every entry, filed exactly where his own hand had put it,

waiting with a patience that outlasted his own for the one reader who would ever think to ask what any of it had actually cost him to collect.

It never once, in the end, got him.

END OF CHAPTER TWO